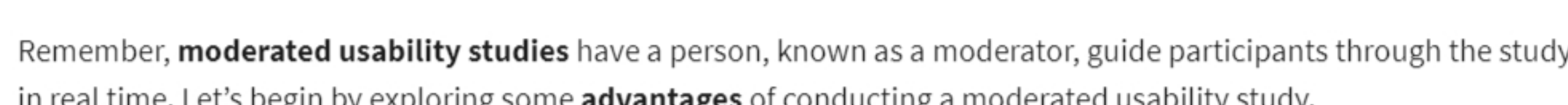


- Observe a mock usability study
- Explore usability study best practices
- Identify biases when interviewing participants

Now that you know the basics of moderated and unmoderated usability studies, let's dig into the details and explore the benefits and limitations of each type of study.



- With all of these benefits in mind, it might seem like moderated usability studies are the way to go! However, it's important to note that moderated usability studies have some **disadvantages** too.

- The diagram is a comparison chart titled "Unmoderated usability study". It is divided into two main sections: "Advantages" on the left and "Disadvantages" on the right. The "Advantages" section features a green header, a thumbs-up icon, and a list of five benefits. The "Disadvantages" section features a red header, a thumbs-down icon, and a list of seven drawbacks. The entire chart is set against a light gray background with white lines separating the sections.

Unmoderated usability study

Advantages

 - Natural product interactions
 - More participants
 - Easier scheduling
 - Inexpensive
 - More privacy
 - Simple user journeys

Disadvantages

 - No real-time support
 - No live follow ups
 - Potential distractions
 - Possible privacy breaches
 - Inaccessibility
 - More data to analyze
 - Simple user journeys only

Alternatively, **unmoderated usability studies** have participants test the prototypes without human guidance. An unmoderated study can be done by recording a participant's screen or having the participant give feedback on tasks. Since there's nobody to assist, it's super important that your designs are clear and accessible to all users.

Let's start with some **advantages** of conducting an unmoderated usability study.

- **Natural product interactions.** Because users are mostly unsupervised while completing tasks in the product, they're more likely to use the product naturally and intuitively. This can lead to a more accurate understanding of the user's experience in the real world.
- **More participants.** Unmoderated studies make it easier to include more participants because you don't need to spend time guiding each participant live. You can also recruit participants in different time zones and with different availability, like outside of standard working hours. Keep in mind that you want to have a minimum of five participants, which is a large enough sample size to gain valuable feedback, and a maximum of eight participants, since there is often diminishing return on investment if additional participants are added to the study.
- **Easier scheduling.** Unmoderated usability studies allow participants to complete tasks on their own time and in their own space because there is no need for a moderator. If a participant does not show up or needs to reschedule the session, it's easier to do so when it's unmoderated, since the participant can do it on their own time.
- **Inexpensive.** Unmoderated studies are more cost-effective than moderated studies, since they don't require a facilitator or physical location to conduct the study.
- **More privacy.** If the product involves sensitive or personal topics, an unmoderated setting can make participants feel more comfortable answering honestly and sharing their perspective, since they aren't required to speak with someone face-to-face.
- **Simple user journeys.** Unmoderated usability studies work well to test straightforward user journeys and simple features of a product, since participants don't need a lot of guidance to complete tasks.

Of course, unmoderated usability studies have some **disadvantages** too.

- **No real-time support.** If participants don't understand the wording of the prompt or if they have technical difficulties, there is usually no one to provide support.
- **No live follow-ups.** Unmoderated usability studies don't give the UX team an opportunity to ask participants real-time follow-up questions or to clarify their feedback. This can be limiting if the participant does not explain their problem in detail because there is no way to follow up while the UX team watches the recording of the session later.
- **Potential distractions.** There is little to no control over the environment to ensure you have the participant's full attention. Without a moderator present, participants could multitask and not be focused on the key activities in the study.
- **Possible privacy breaches.** To test the use of your product in an unmoderated study, you might need to upload your designs to a testing platform, which participants access from their homes. This means there is less control over your intellectual property.
- **Inaccessibility.** The testing platform you use to conduct remote research might not be equally accessible to users with disabilities or people who use assistive technology.
- **More data to analyze.** Because there is no moderator to control the conversation of the session, the information you collect might be off topic or irrelevant to your research.
- **Simple user journeys only.** Unmoderated studies are not great for testing complex user journeys because if a user gets stuck with a complex prototype, there's no one to guide them through the process.

Start testing

When you're choosing whether to conduct a moderated or an unmoderated usability study, there are a lot of things to consider! Both can help you get the research data you need to improve your product; it's just a matter of deciding which one will do it *better*. Keeping these advantages and disadvantages in mind can help you make the right choice for your specific project and research goals.

Mark as completed